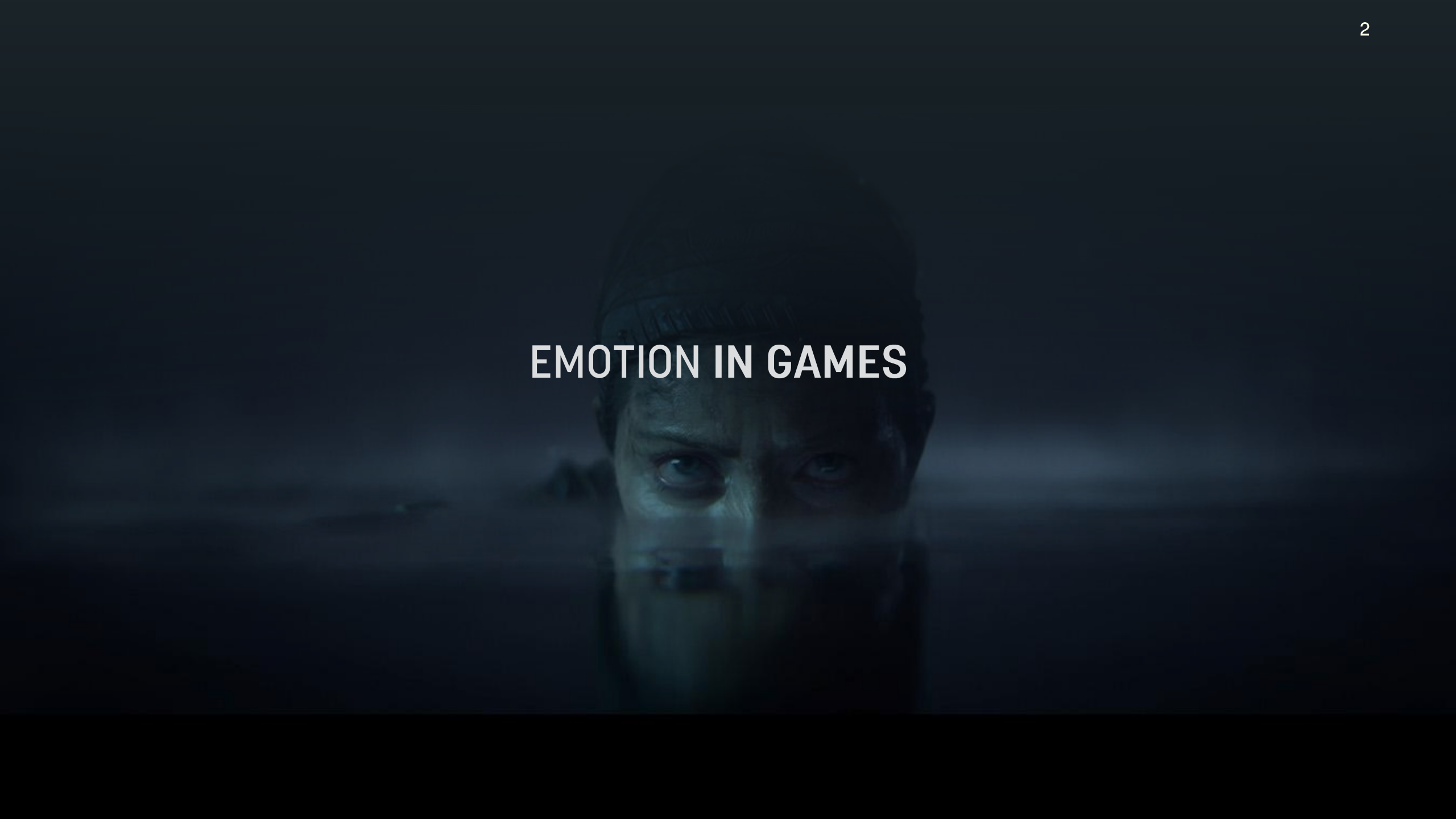


INTRODUCTION TO GAMES

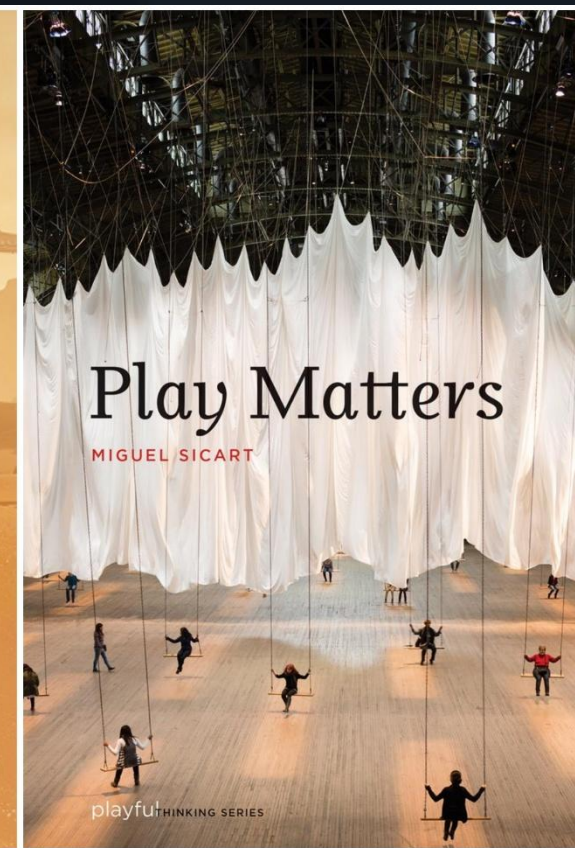
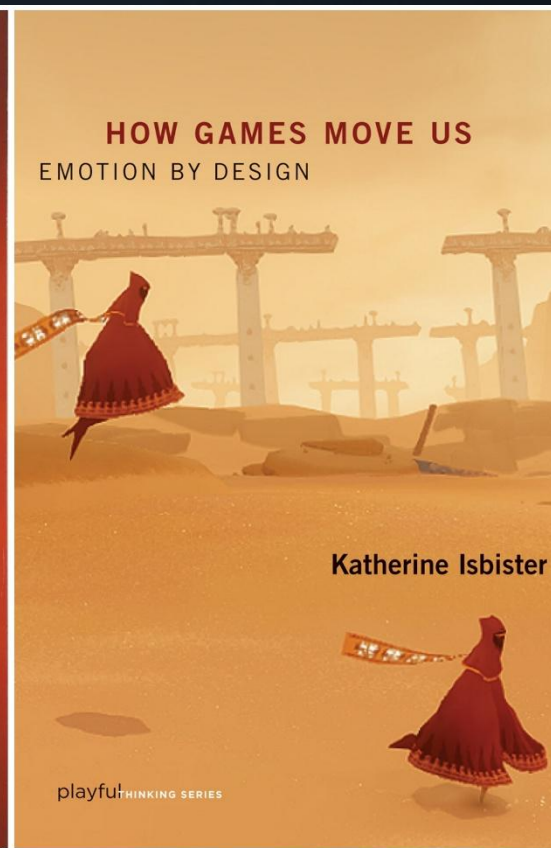
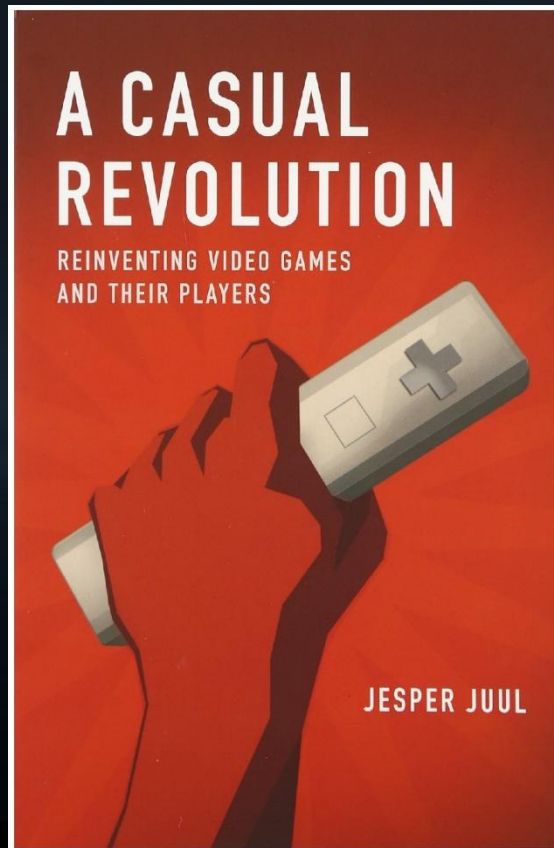
Game Ideation 02

A dark, atmospheric image of a person's face, possibly a character from a game, with the text "EMOTION IN GAMES" overlaid. The face is partially obscured by shadows and has a serious expression. The background is dark and blurry.

EMOTION IN GAMES

HOW GAMES MOVE US: EMOTION BY DESIGN

- Based on Katherine Isbister's book (MIT Press, 2016)



ABOUT THE AUTHOR

- Katherine Isbister: game researcher and designer
- Works at the intersection of HCI, game design, and psychology
- Explains how games create emotion and social connection



HER MOTIVATION

- Games are now mainstream culture
- Public debates often oversimplify games
- We need a nuanced vocabulary for game emotions



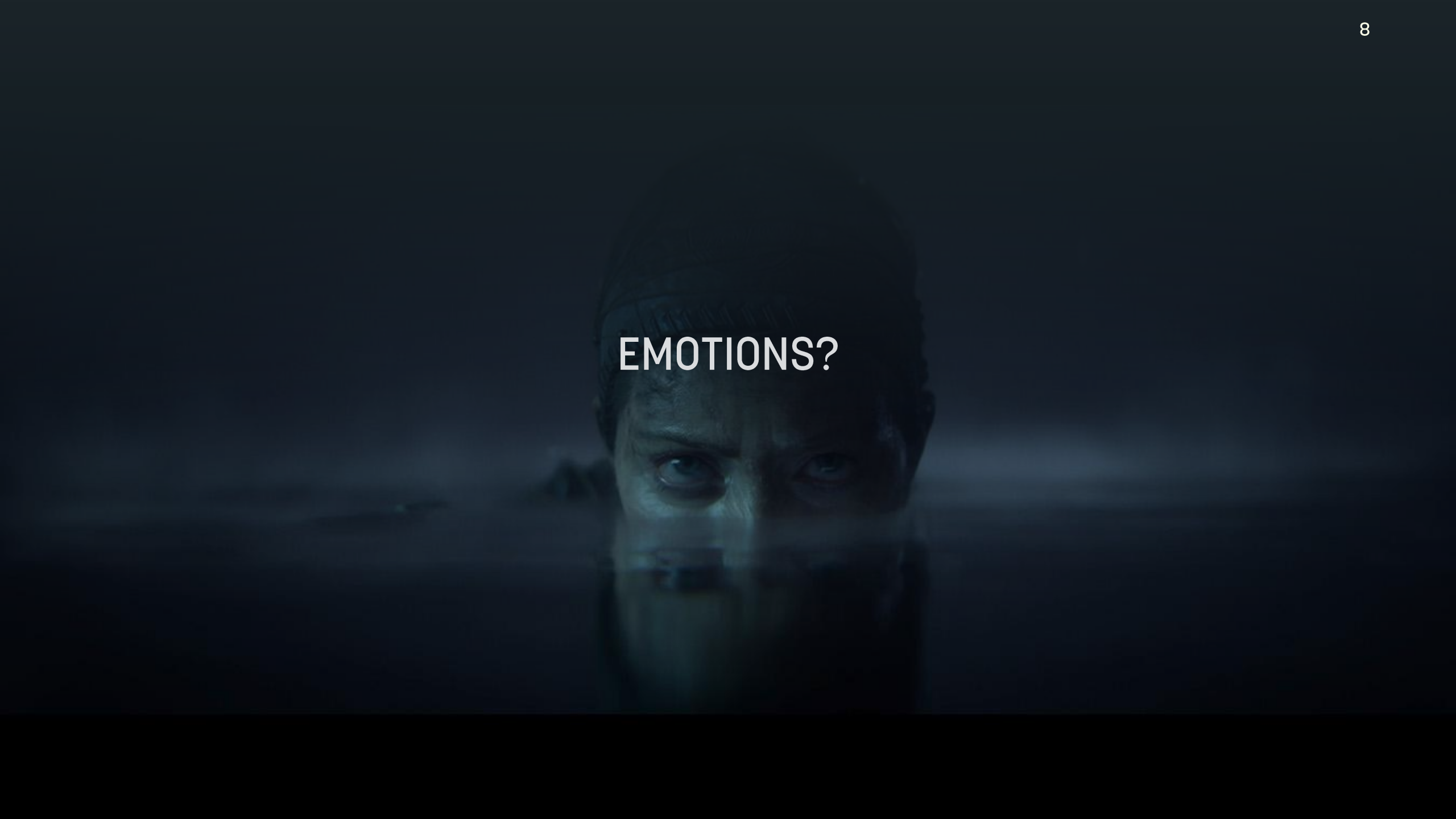
GAMES VS OTHER MEDIA

- We easily distinguish genres
- We rarely differentiate emotional profiles of games
- Aim: understand what different games actually do emotionally



STRUCTURE OF THIS LECTURE

- Emotion basics
- Games as emotional media
- Solo play: avatars, NPCs, customization
- Social play: coordinated action and social situations
- Bodies at play: movement and emotion
- Networked play: intimacy at a distance
- Design implications and discussion



EMOTIONS?

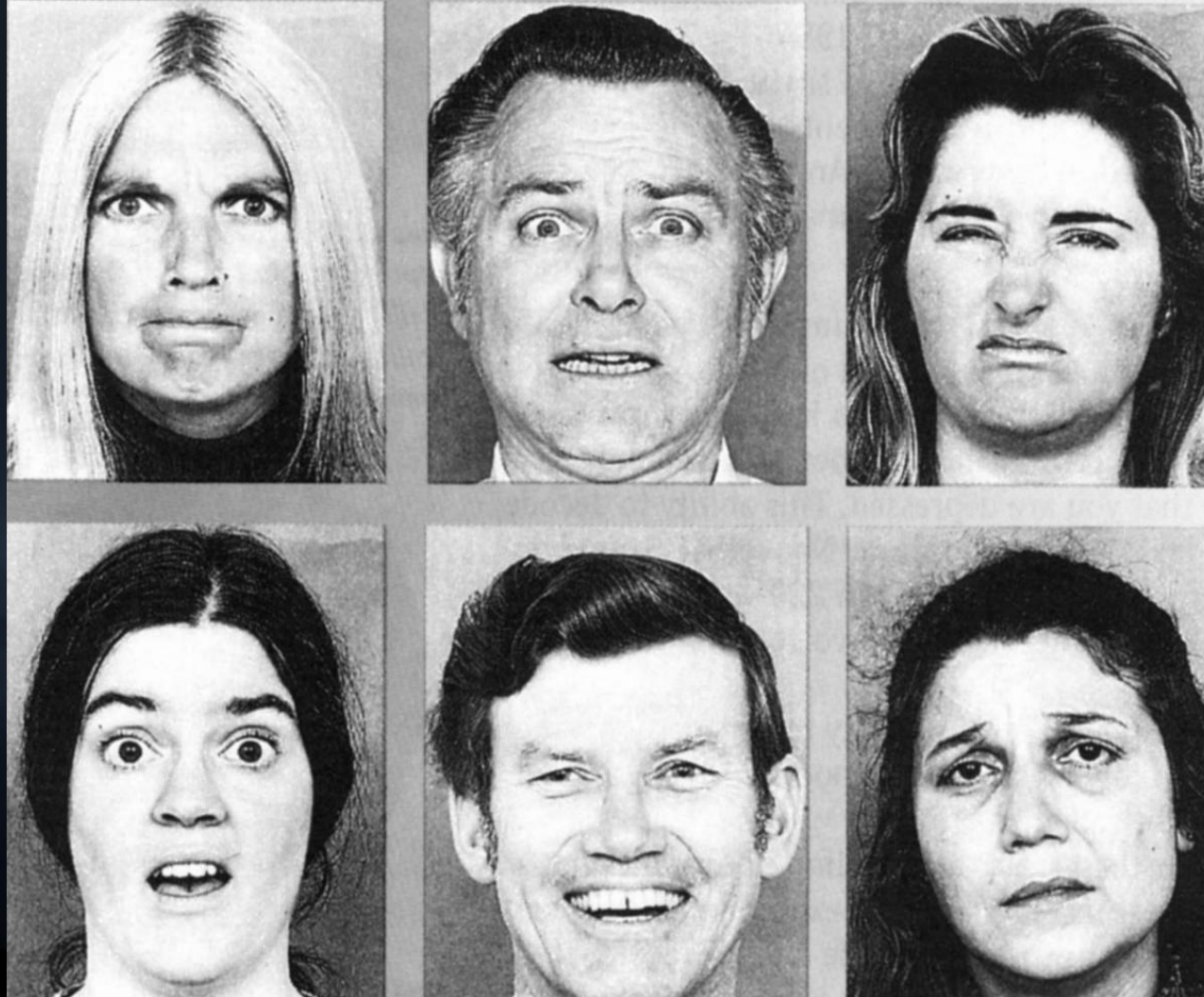
DEFINING EMOTIONS

KEY DIFFERENCES BETWEEN **MOODS** vs **EMOTIONS**

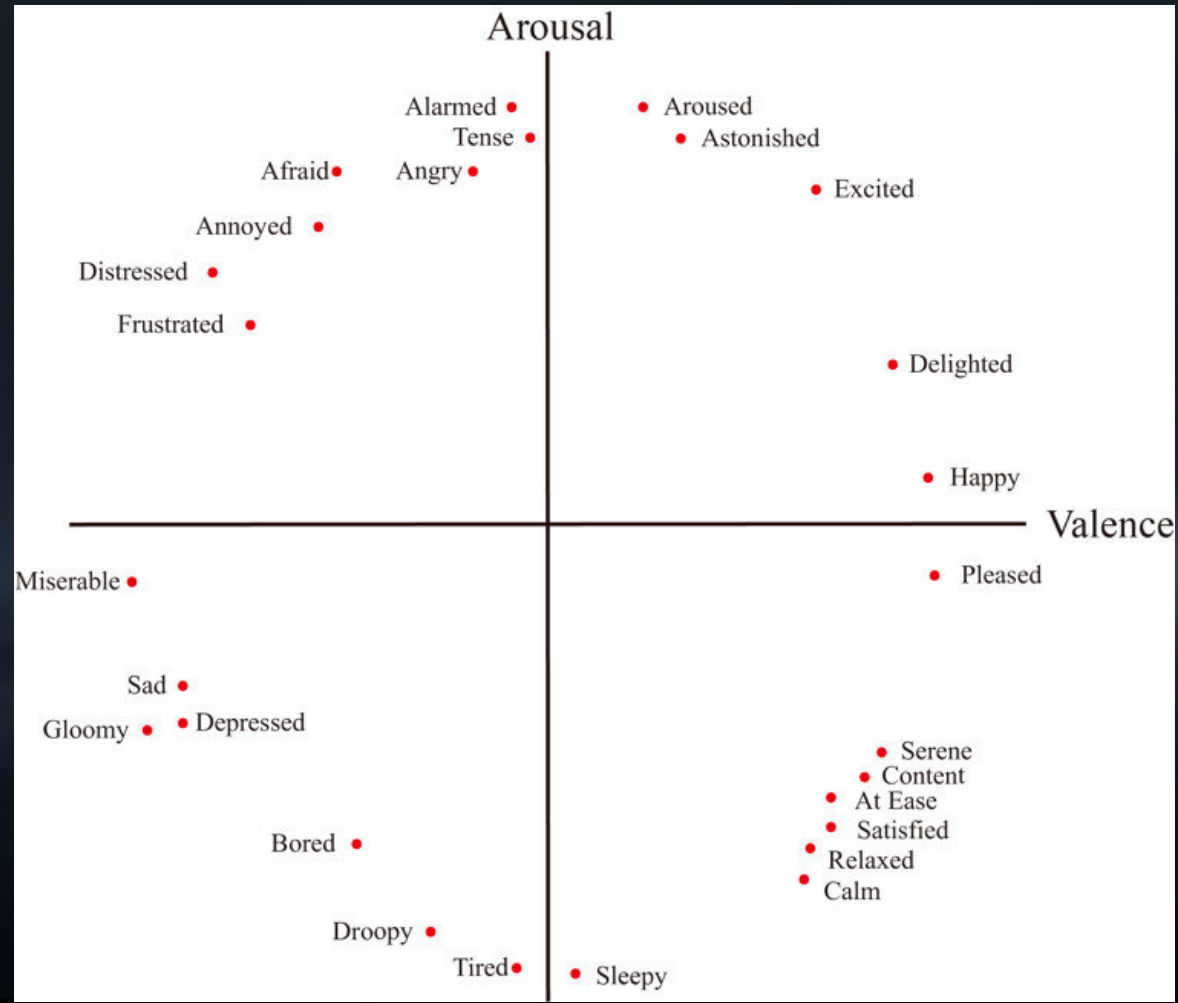
- **DURATION** MINUTES TO HOURS
- **PROVOCATION** LOWERS THRESHOLD NEEDED TO TRIGGER EMOTIONS
- **MODULATION** REGULATION MOSTLY UNAFFECTED
- **EXPRESSION** NO UNIQUE NONVERBAL EXPRESSIONS
- **AWARENESS** DIFFICULT TO IDENTIFY EXACT TRIGGER(S) CAUSING MOOD

- **DURATION** SECONDS TO MINUTES
- **PROVOCATION** MORE EASILY EXPERIENCED WITHIN MOODS BELONGING TO SAME "FAMILY"
- **MODULATION** MORE DIFFICULT TO REGULATE IF EXPERIENCED WITHIN MOOD
- **EXPRESSION** UNIVERSAL FACIAL EXPRESSIONS
- **AWARENESS** TRIGGERS MORE EASILY IDENTIFIABLE

BIG SIX



CIRCUMPLEX MODEL



HOW DOES THIS CONNECT TO GAMES?



THE PLAYER'S PERSPECTIVE



EMOTIONS



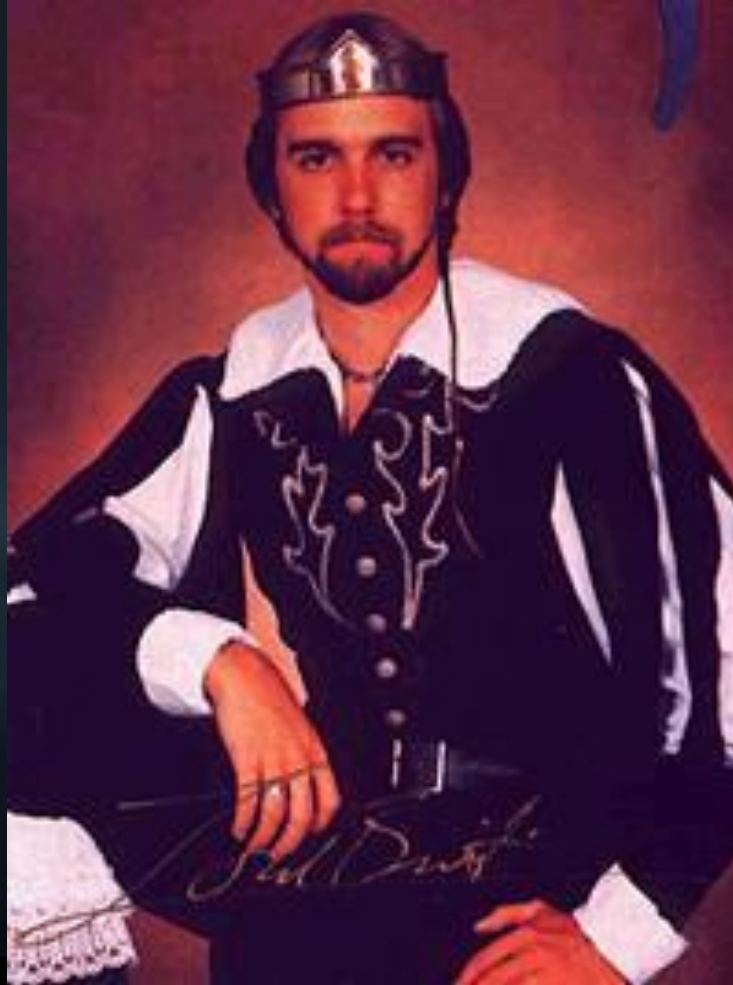
EMOTIONS



EMOTIONS



THE DESIGNER'S PERSPECTIVE



ZORK

```
Up a Tree                                     Score: 5      Moves: 6
This is a forest, with trees in all directions. To the east, there appears to
be sunlight.

>go east
Forest Path
This is a path winding through a dimly lit forest. The path heads north-south
here. One particularly large tree with some low branches stands at the edge of
the path.

>climb tree
Up a Tree
You are about 10 feet above the ground nestled among some large branches. The
nearest branch above you is above your reach.
Beside you on the branch is a small bird's nest.
In the bird's nest is a large egg encrusted with precious jewels, apparently
scavenged by a childless songbird. The egg is covered with fine gold inlay,
and ornamented in lapis lazuli and mother-of-pearl. Unlike most eggs, this one
is hinged and closed with a delicate looking clasp. The egg appears extremely
fragile.

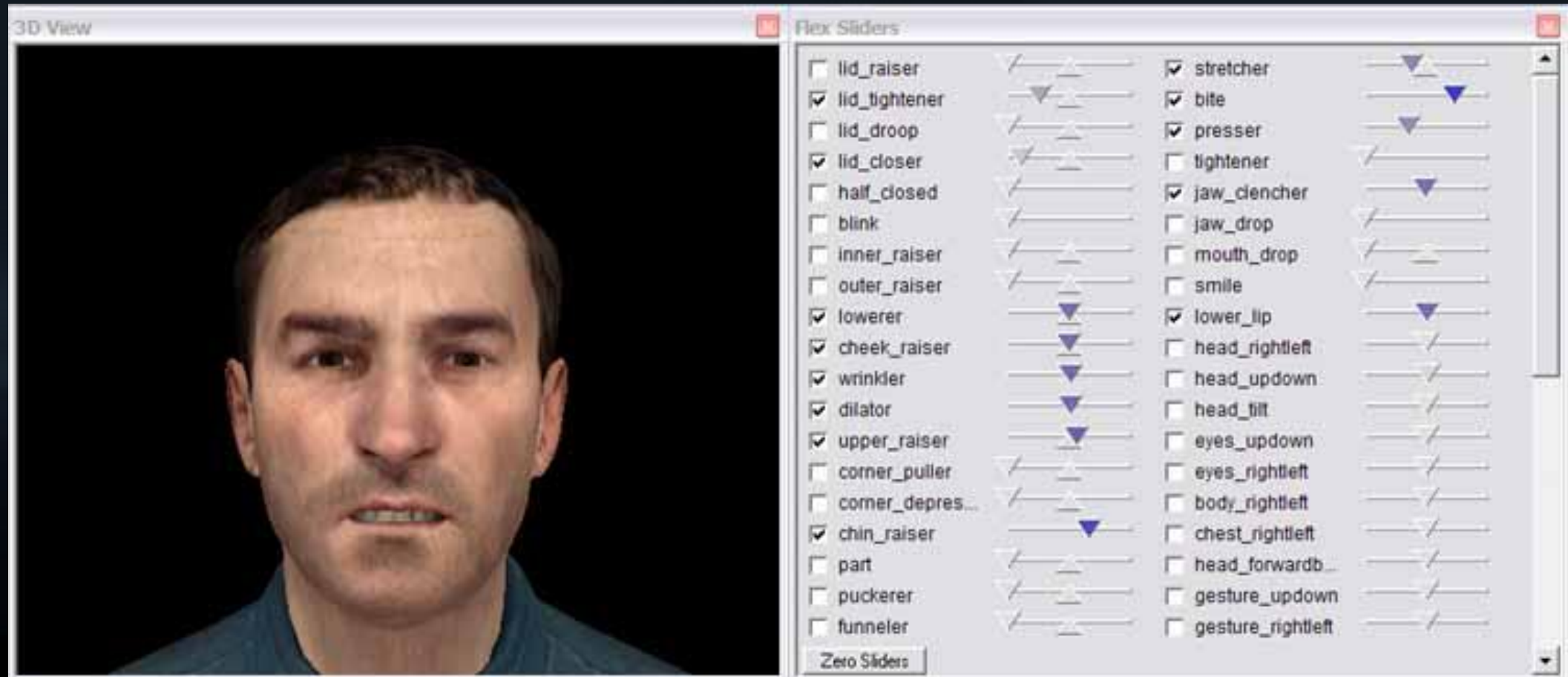
>get egg
Taken.

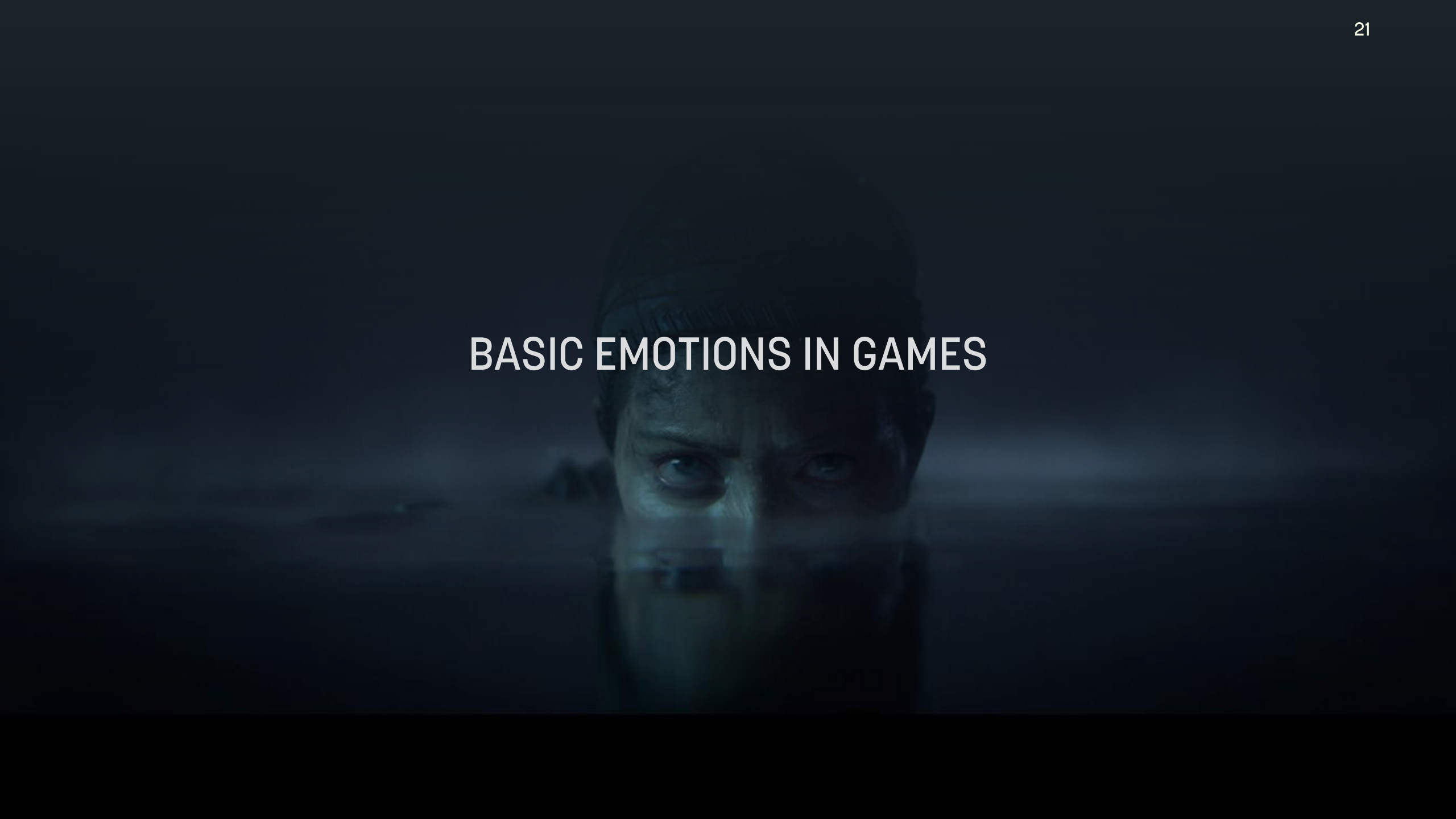
>_
```

HELLBLADE: SENUA'S SACRIFICE



HALF LIFE 2: SOURCE ENGINE



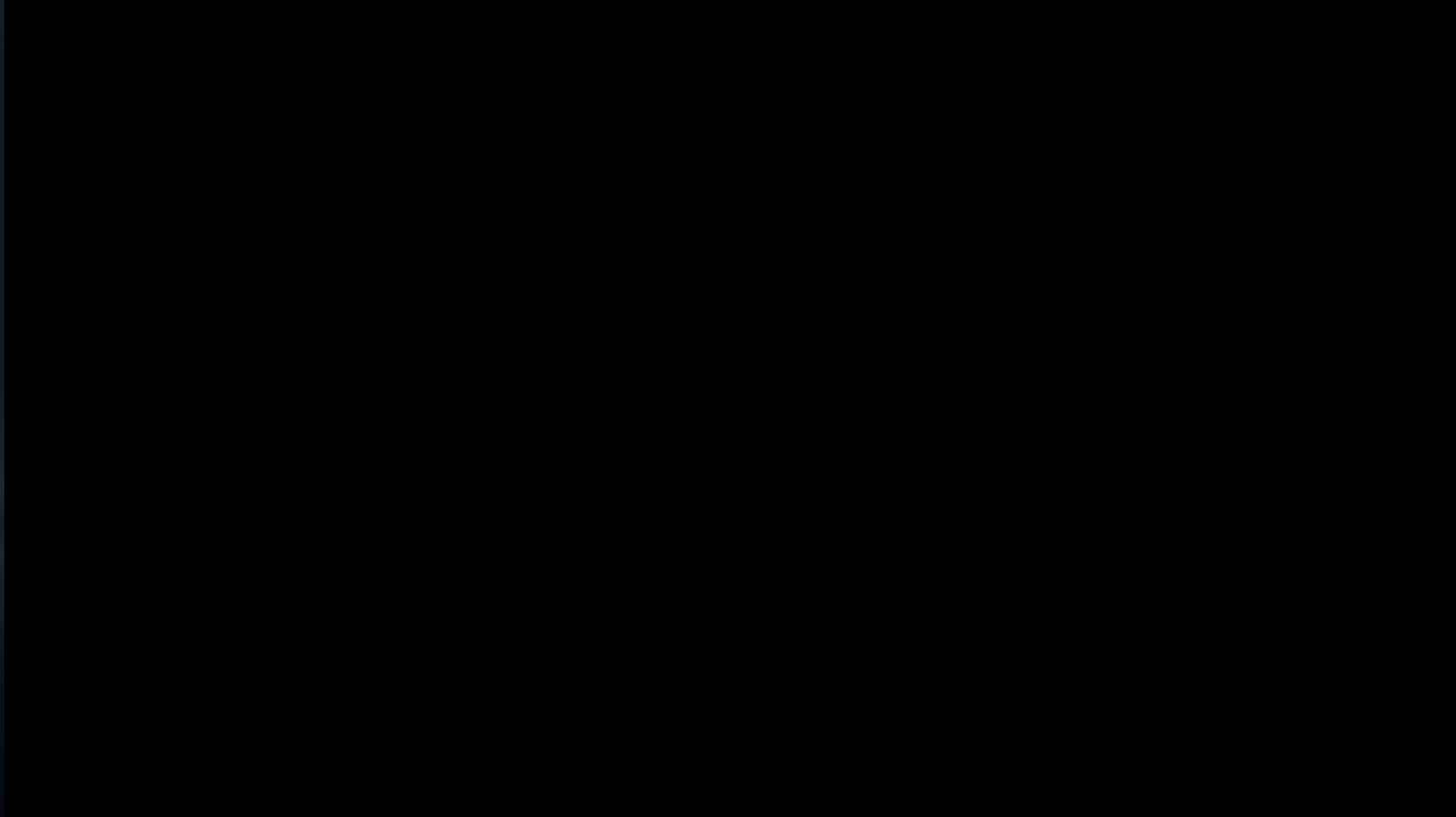


BASIC EMOTIONS IN GAMES

JOURNEY



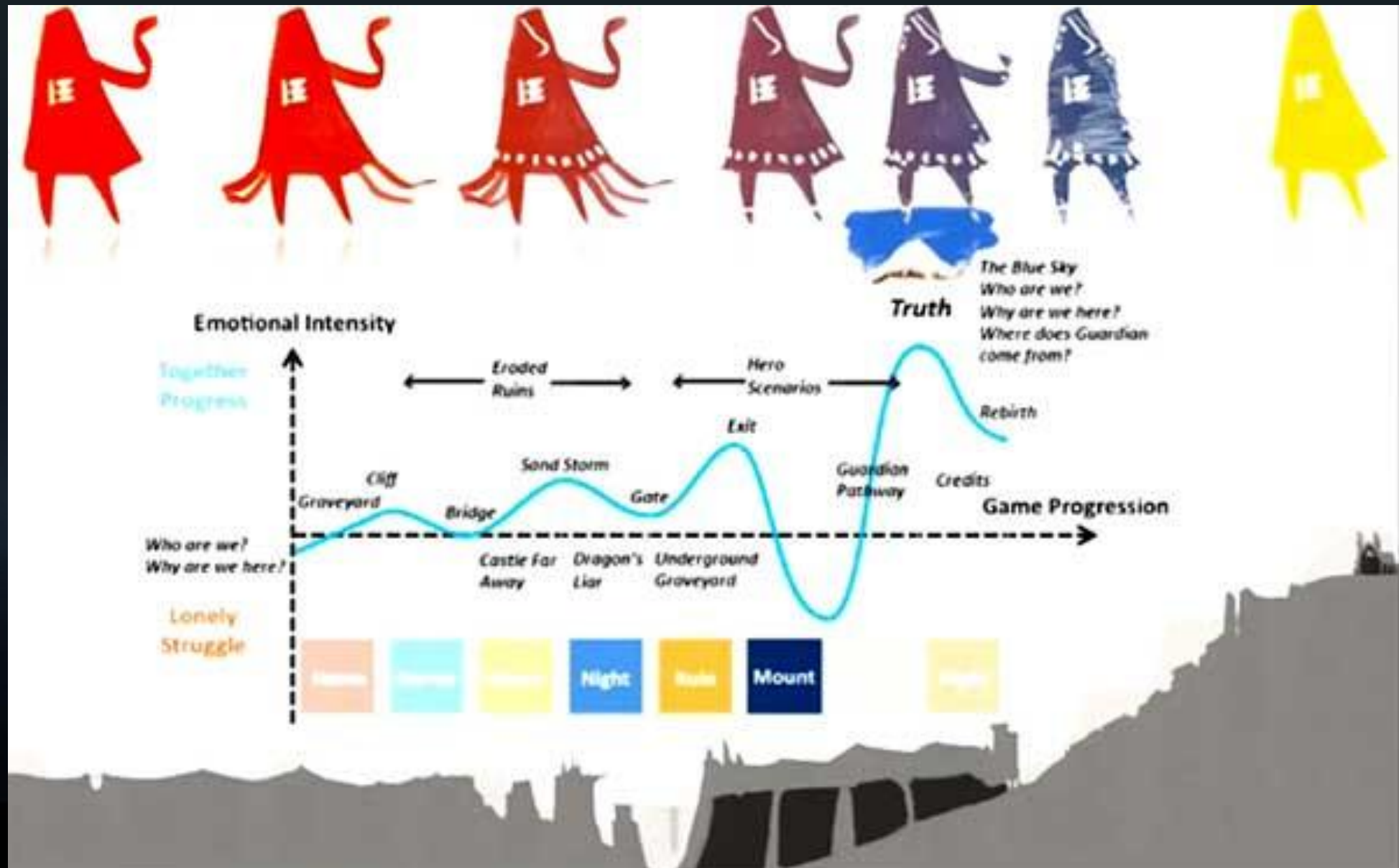
JOURNEY



JOURNEY: HARD FACTS

- Developer: thatgamecompany
- Release: 2012
- Publisher: Sony (SCEA)
- Director: Jenova Chen
- Team size: 7 (Start), 12 (End)















JOURNEY: PROCESS



JOURNEY: PROCESS

Ninja

- 3D Engine (previous game: Flower)
- Art Style: ancient greece
- Character: arms (warrior)
- Character: masculine appearance



JOURNEY: PROCESS



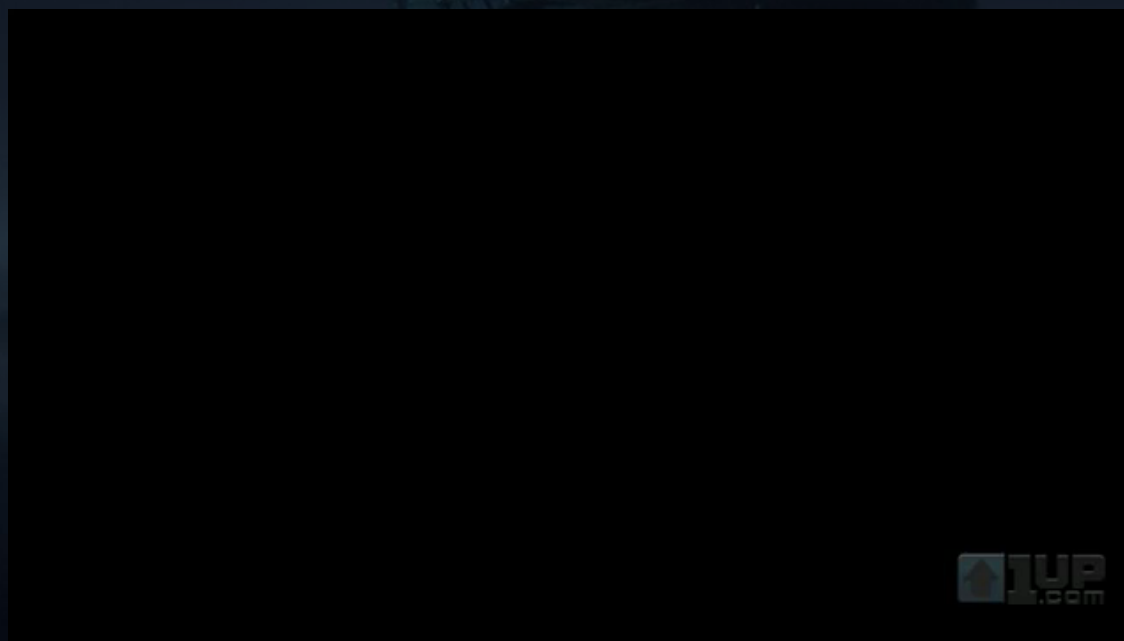
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4di1KBqdOWo&list=PLvsjJ4xD-kloD-N30yB0oUPAZTrX3fpR8>

JOURNEY: PROCESS

- Ninja prototype



JOURNEY: PROCESS



<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4di1KBqdOWo&list=PLvsjJ4xD-kloD-N30yB0oUPAZTrX3fpR8>

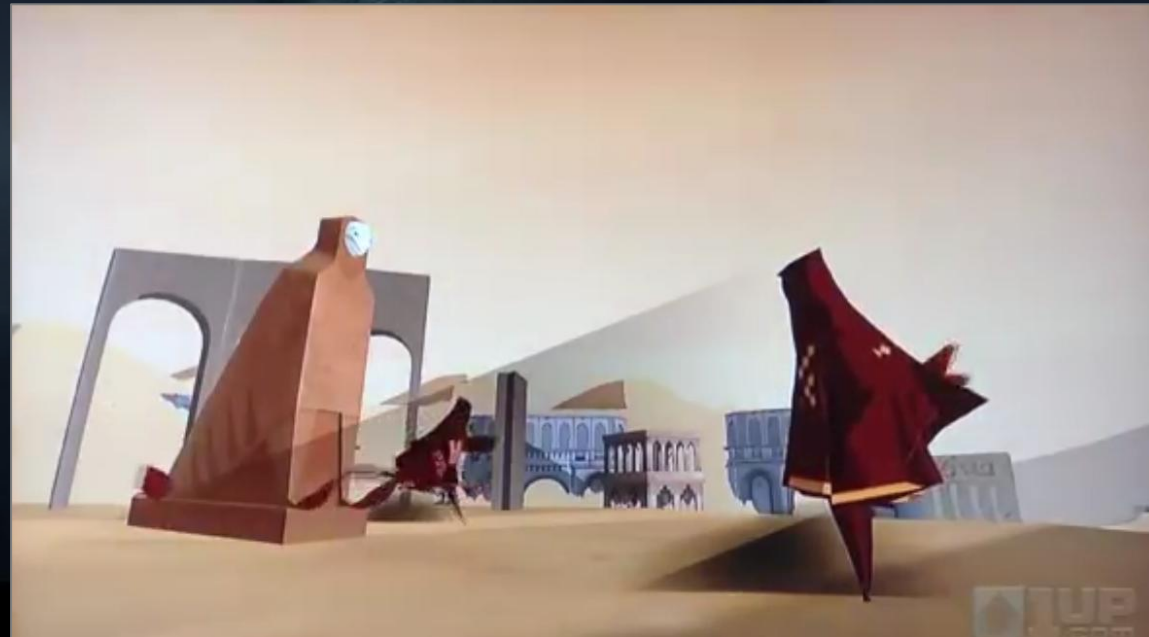
JOURNEY: PROCESS

- Ninja outcome
- Character: arms were removed
- Focus: social interaction - no battle!
- Character: should be more feminine
- Omitting reference to greek art



JOURNEY: PROCESS

- Chicken prototype

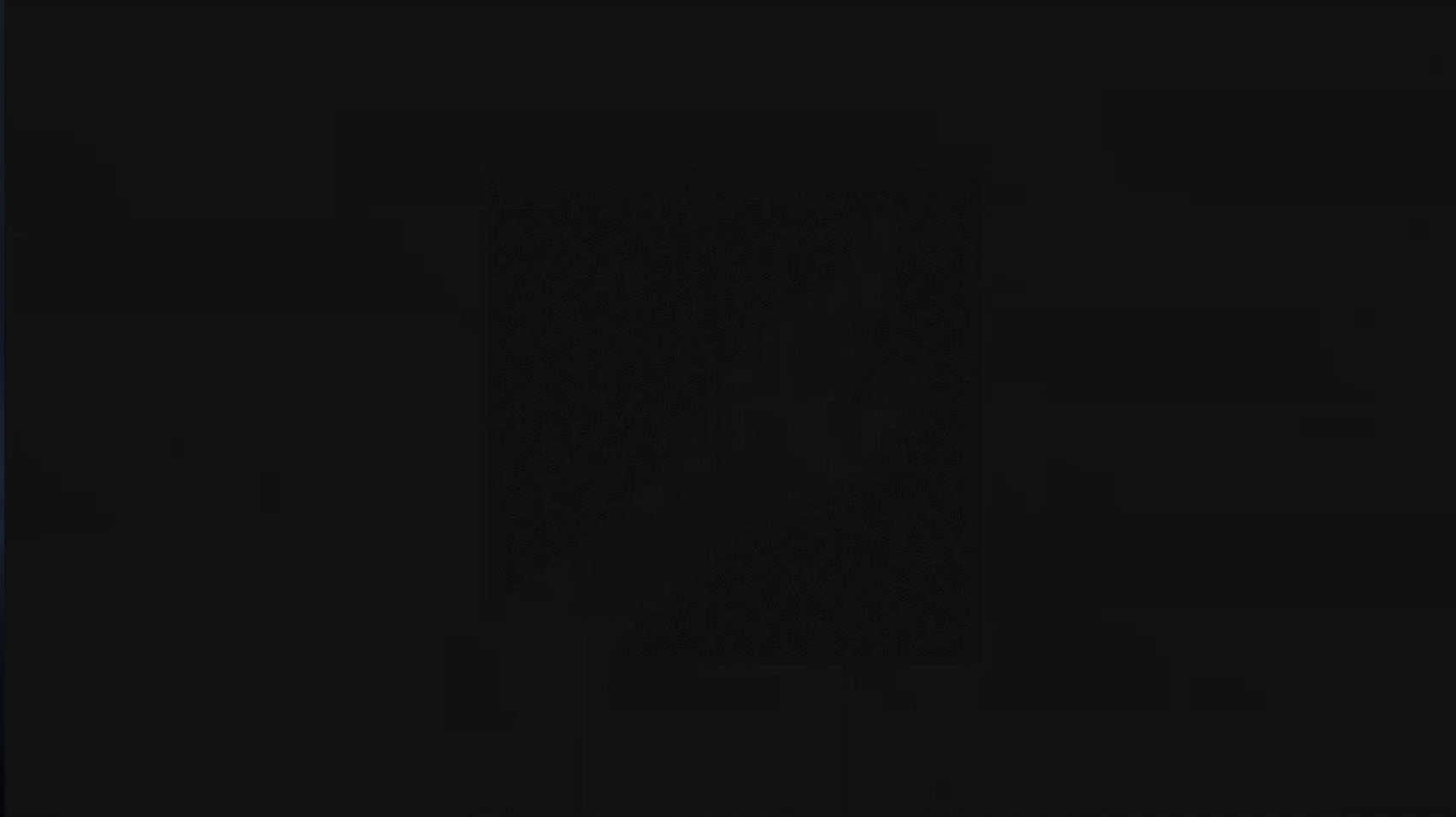


JOURNEY: PROCESS



https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=21_CK1S7Owg&list=PLvsjJ4xD-kloD-N30yB0oUPAZTrX3fpR8

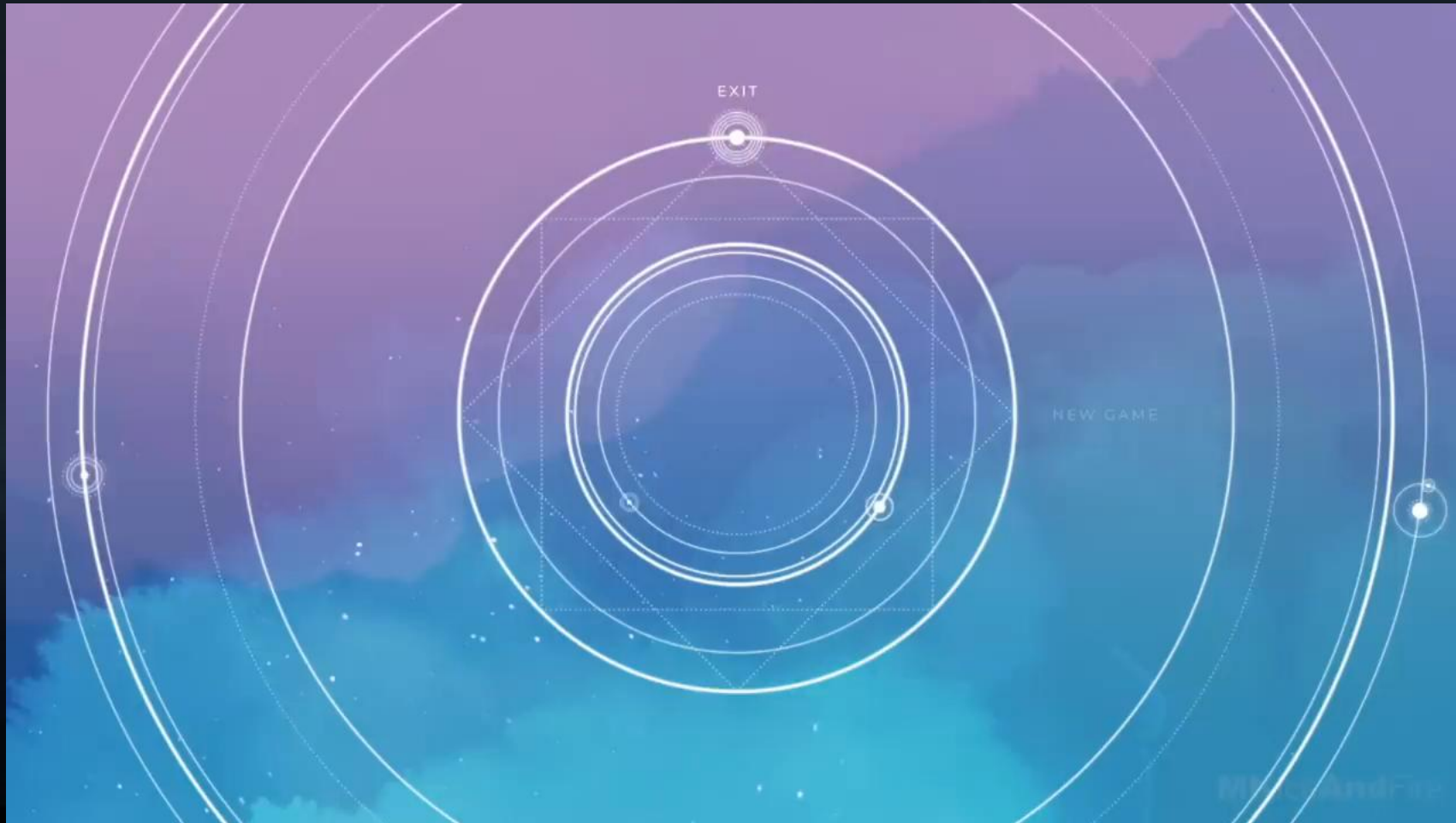
BASIC EMOTIONS: JOY IN FLOWER



BASIC EMOTIONS: SADNESS IN GRIS



BASIC EMOTIONS: SADNESS IN GRIS

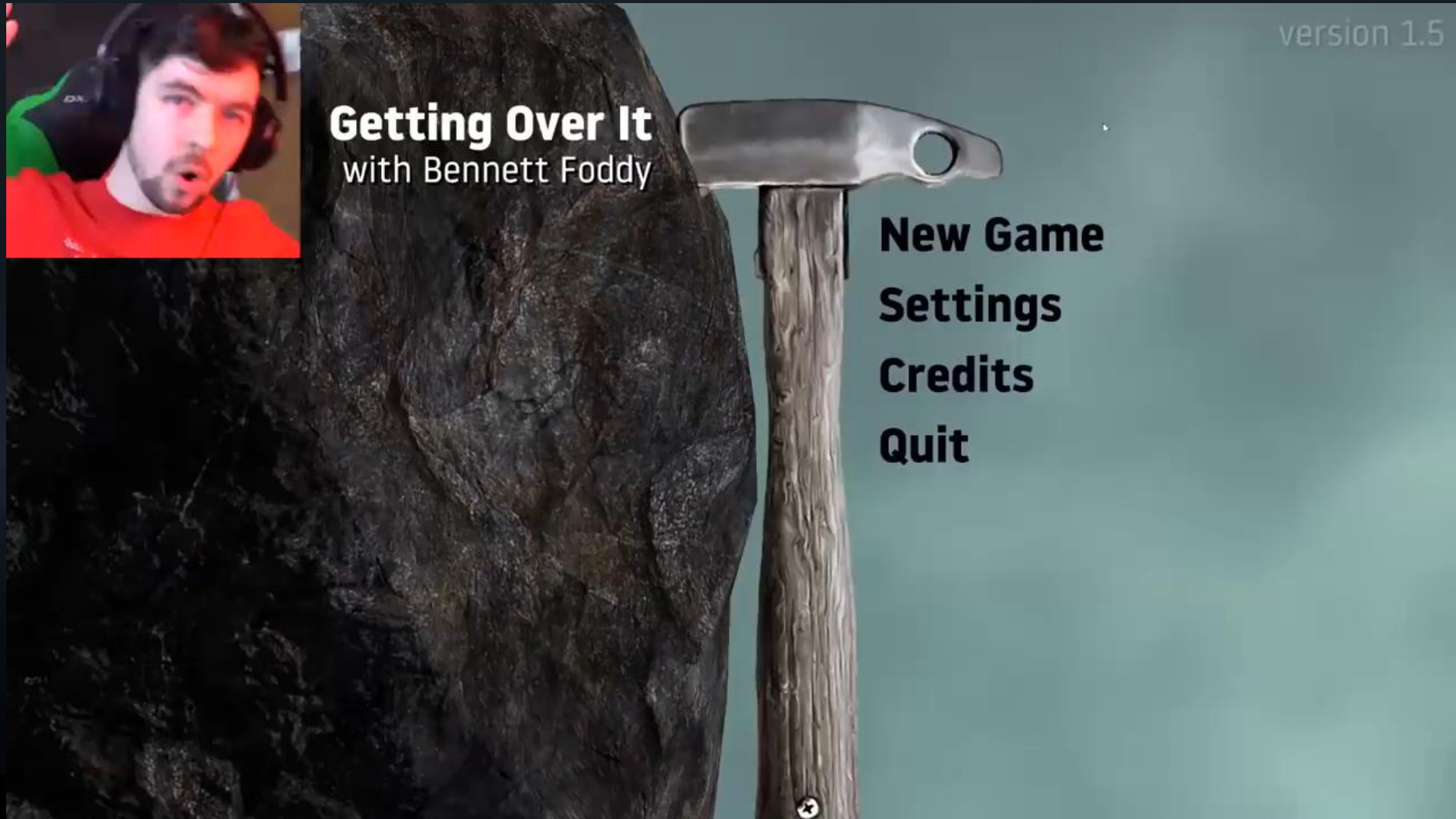


BASIC EMOTIONS: ANGER



Getting Over It
with Bennett Foddy

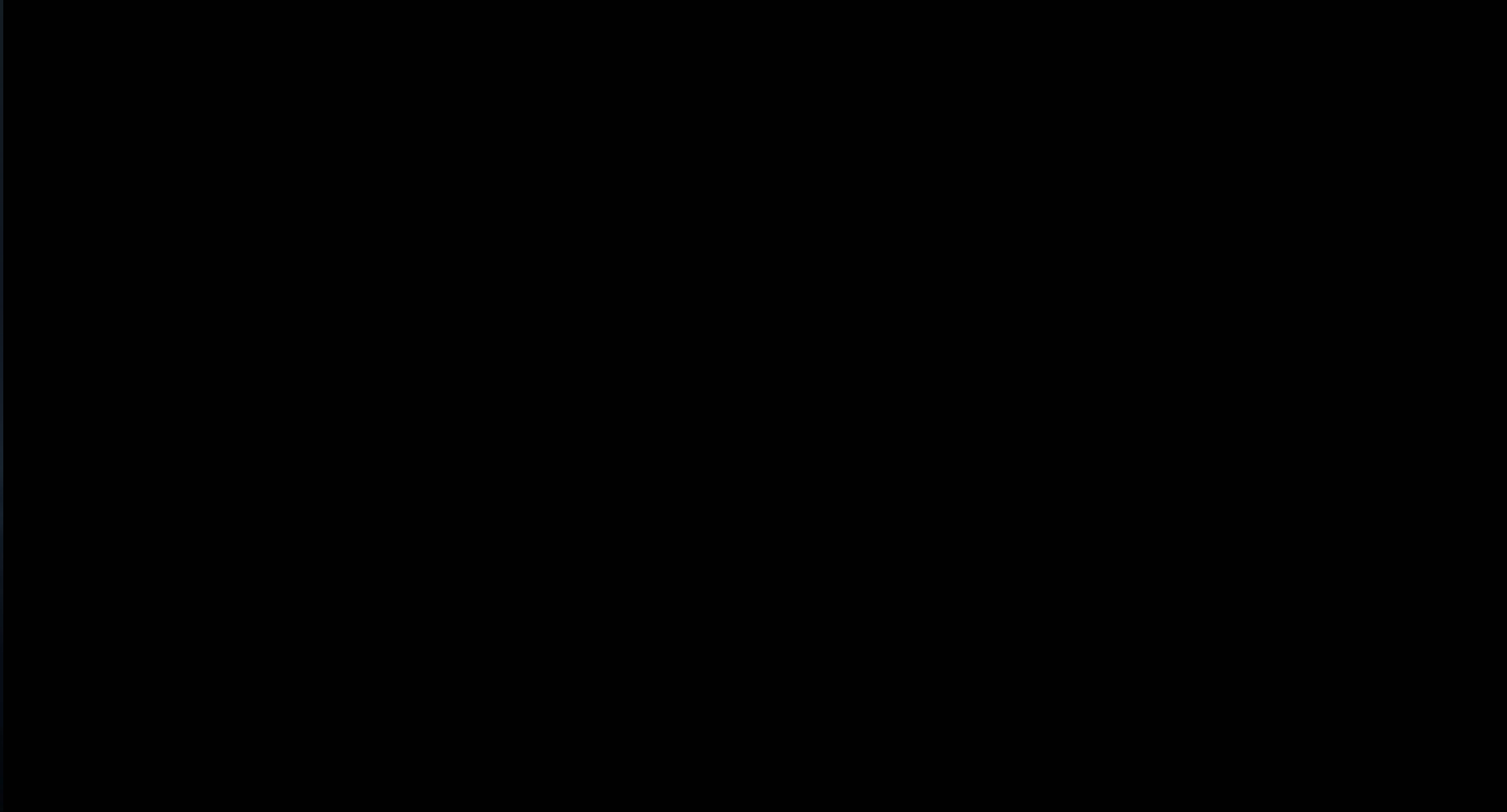
BASIC EMOTIONS: ANGER



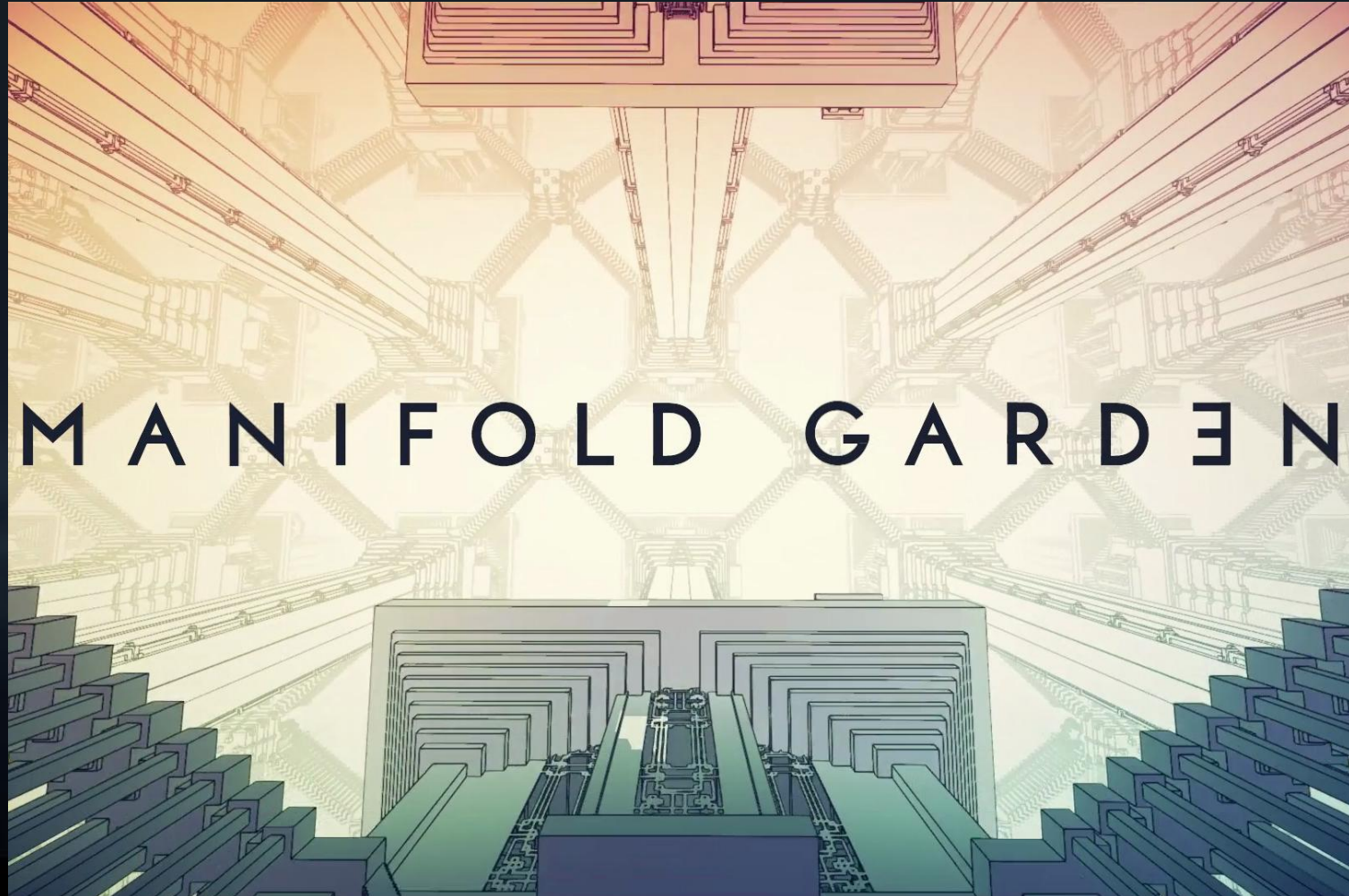
BASIC EMOTIONS: ANGER



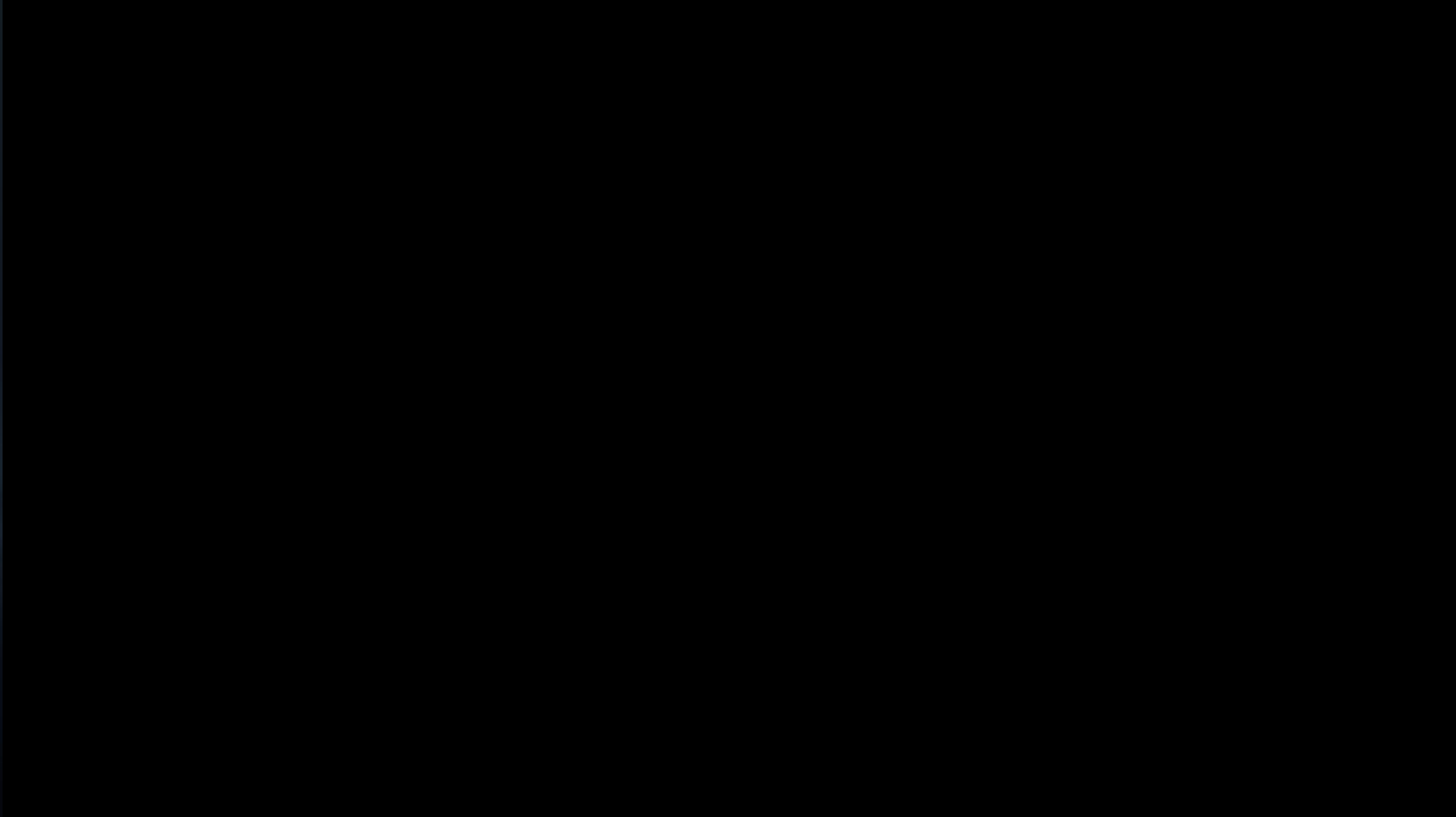
BASIC EMOTIONS: ANGER



BASIC EMOTIONS: SURPRISE



BASIC EMOTIONS: SURPRISE



BASIC EMOTIONS: DISGUST

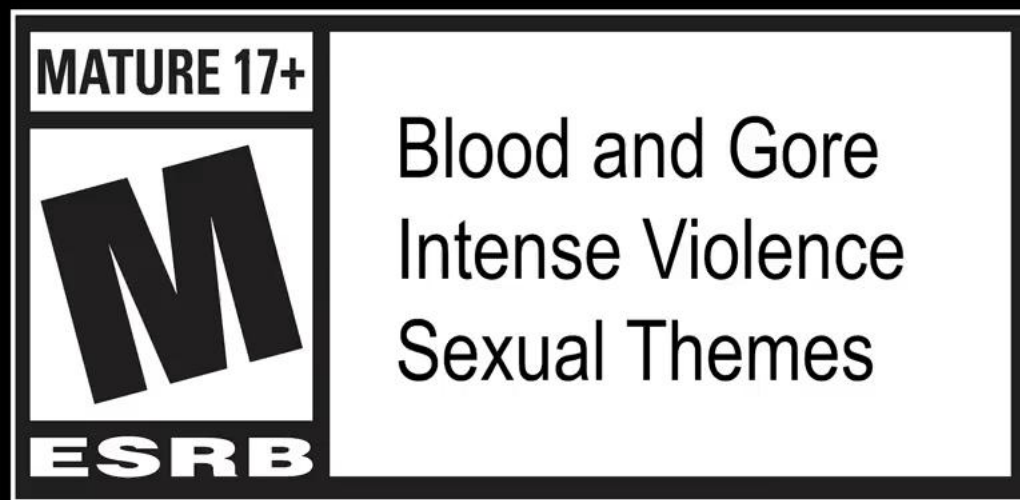




FACTS

- Ebb Software (Serbia)
- Unreal Engine 4
- Basically: I love letter to H.R. Giger
- Development time: 2014 - 2022
- Playtime: 6 to 8 hours

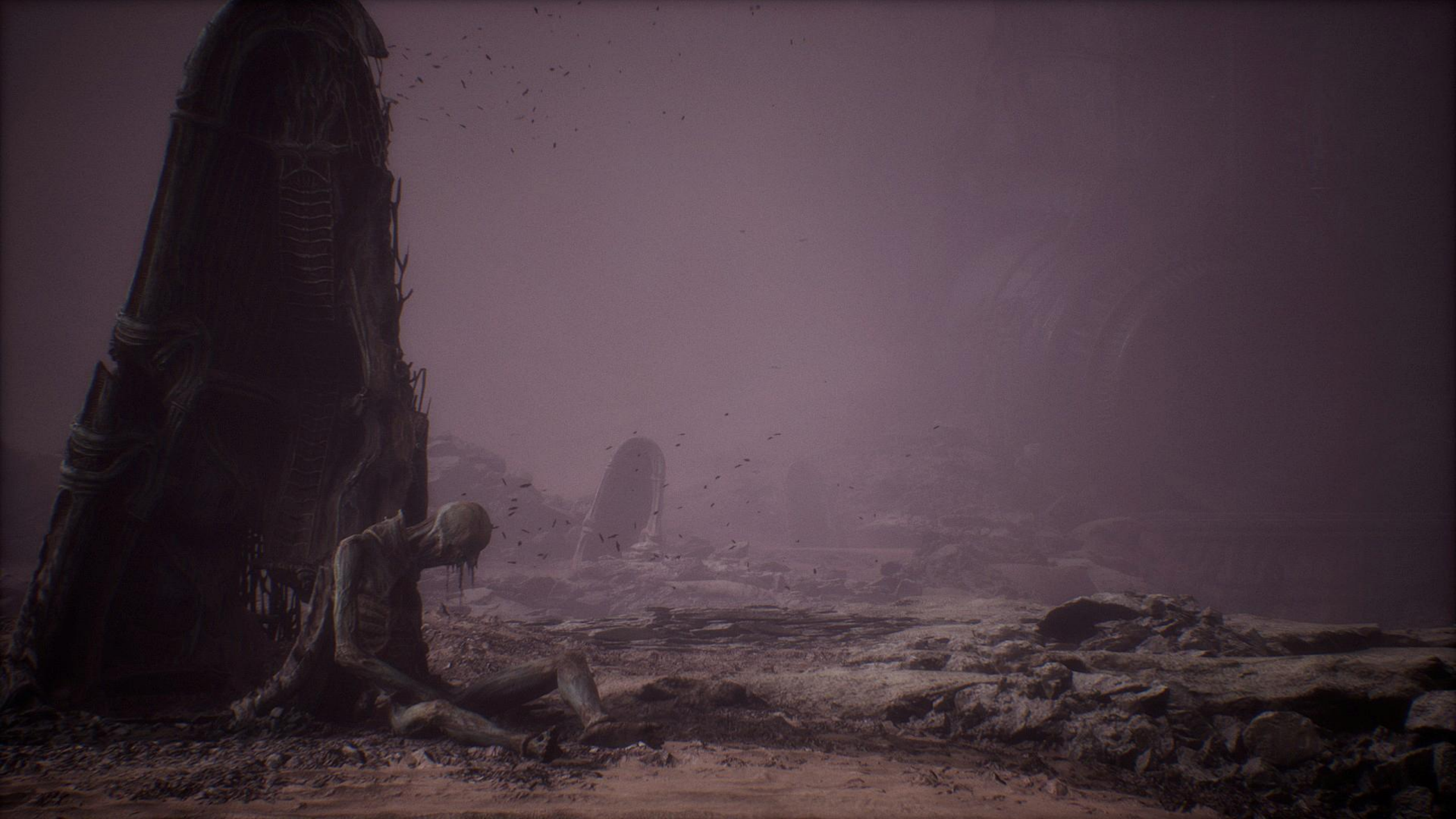




























Zork Nemesis (1996)



Myst (1993)



I have no mouth and I must scream



META-LAYER: EMOTION IN GAMES

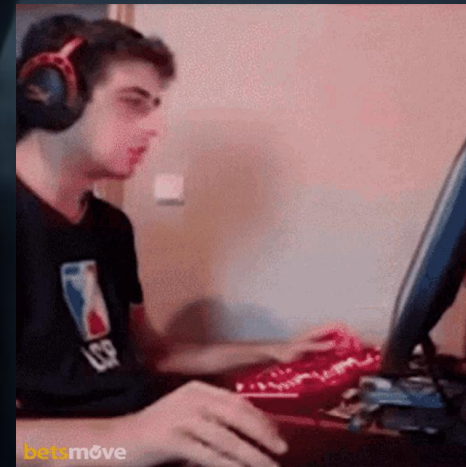
EMOTIONS & MEDIA BASICS

- Emotions relate to goals and appraisals
- Books and films: we watch others pursue goals
- Games: we pursue goals ourselves



APPRAISAL THEORY IN GAMES

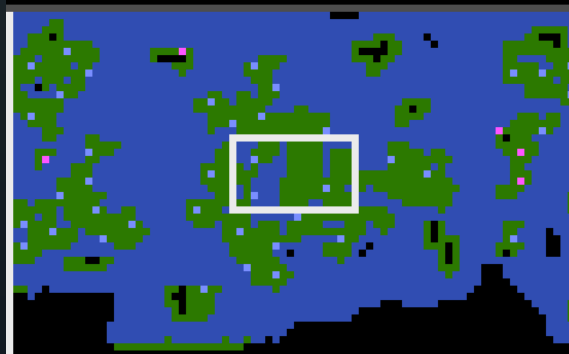
- We continually evaluate events vs. our goals
- Supportive events -> joy, pride, relief
- Blocking events -> anger, frustration, disappointment
- Games as controlled labs for appraisal



MEANINGFUL CHOICE: WHAT MAKES GAMES SPECIAL

- Sid Meier: games as a series of interesting choices
- Agency: actions with consequences
- Responsibility: we own the outcomes





13,420,000A
2477 AD ♀ ●
4210 0.10.0

Deutsch.
Panzer
2 Züge.2
Leipzig
(Wald)
(Straße)



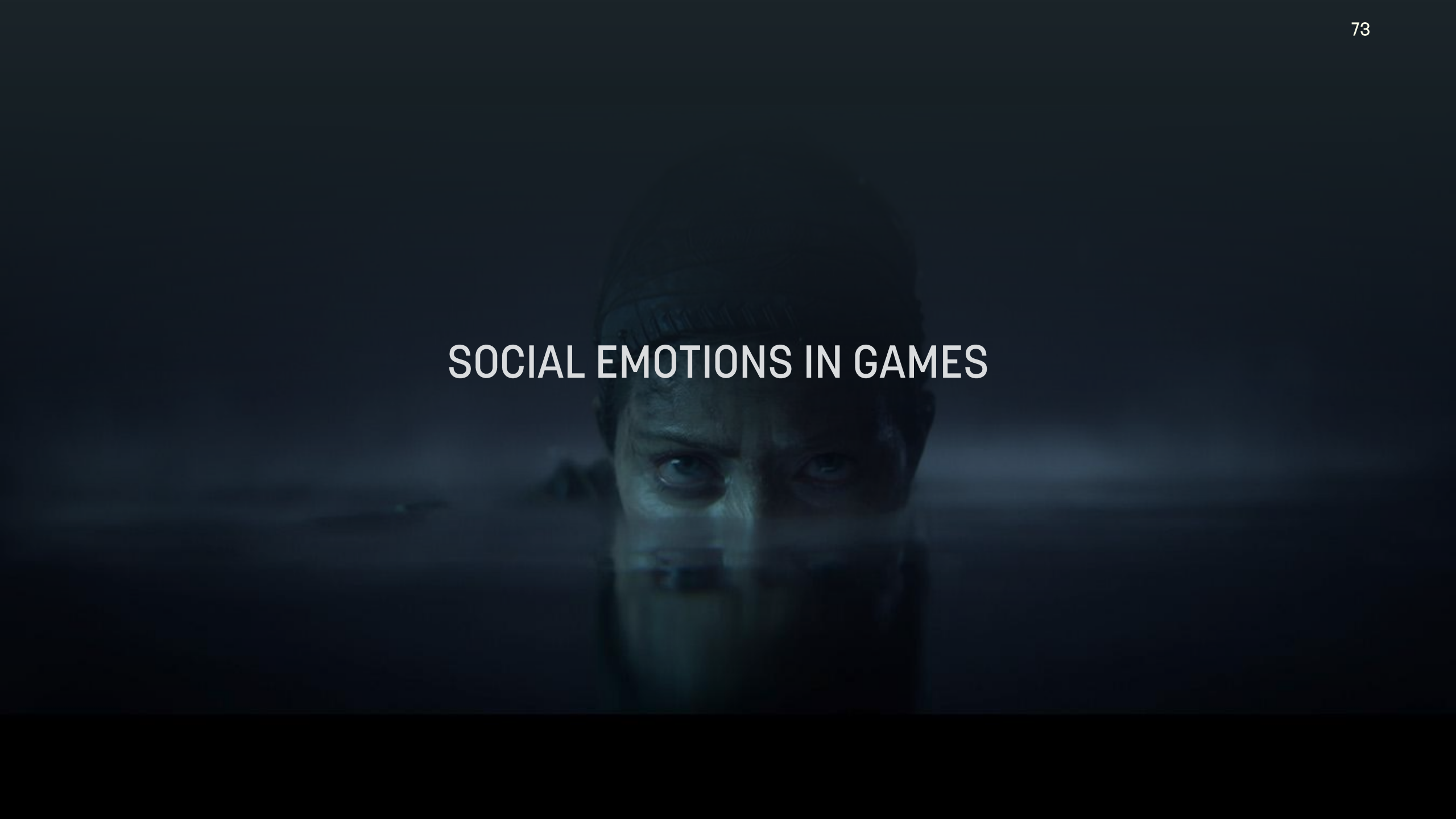
Unholy Alliance

- I'm Good! (Flight Simulators)
- Suspension of Disbelief
(Movies, 16-colors)
- Moral Clarity
- MAD
- Humor/Style/Music/Atmosphere

BRAINS ON GAMES

- Neuroscience studies compare players and watchers
- Controlling the game activates reward circuits more strongly
- Playing feels closer to doing than to watching

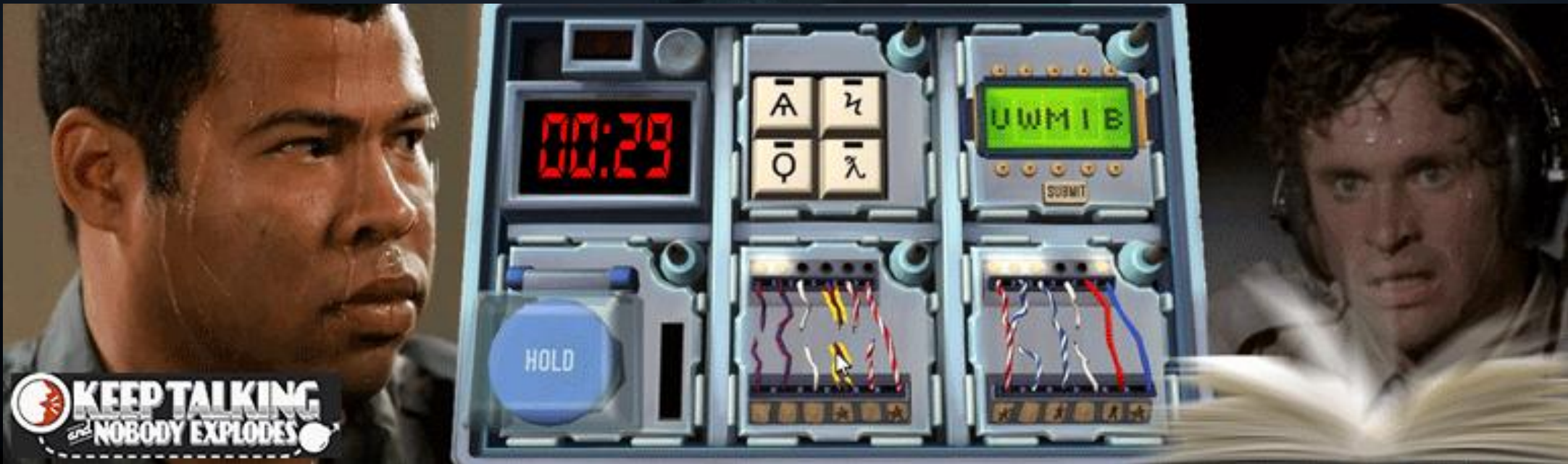




SOCIAL EMOTIONS IN GAMES

SOCIAL EMOTIONS

- Include empathy, affection, camaraderie, guilt, shame, grief
- Other media evoke them via parasocial interaction
- Games add action and responsibility





DESIGN BUILDING BLOCKS

- Solo play: avatars, NPCs, customization
- Social play: coordinated action and role-play
- Embodied play: movement and physicality
- Networked play: relationships over distance



AVATARS AS INHABITABLE PROTAGONISTS

- In games, we act as the protagonist (avatar)
- Avatar = visual body + abilities + social identity
- We do not just watch, we inhabit and perform



Octodad



Keeper

FOUR LEVELS OF PROJECTION

- Visceral: sensorimotor experience (movement, sound, haptics)
- Cognitive: decisions and strategies
- Social: relationships and social reactions
- Fantasy: identity and role (who we get to be)



EXAMPLE: SNOWBOARDING AVATAR

- Visceral: feeling bumps and landings via controller and audio
- Cognitive: choosing routes, tricks, timing
- Social: performing for crowd or friends
- Fantasy: living the identity of a pro snowboarder



AVATARS & COMPLICITY: TRAIN (BRENDA ROMERO)

- Train: efficient resource management reveals a horrific purpose
- Emotions: complicity, discomfort, critical reflection



EVERYDAY EMPATHY: CART LIFE

- Play small-scale street vendors with complex lives
- Handle commuting, inventory, rent, family obligations
- Low-fi aesthetics support mundane realism
- Emotions: stress, care, small joys and failures



HUSH: EDITORIAL GAME

- Play a Rwandan mother soothing her baby
- Typing rhythm to maintain the lullaby
- Failure leads to discovery by soldiers
- Designed to provoke empathy and political awareness



LOVE PLUS: DESIGNED ROMANCE

- Japanese dating sim on Nintendo DS
- Phases: courtship and relationship maintenance
- NPC girlfriends with rich dialogue and routines
- Emotions: infatuation, affection, jealousy



BLURRED BOUNDARIES

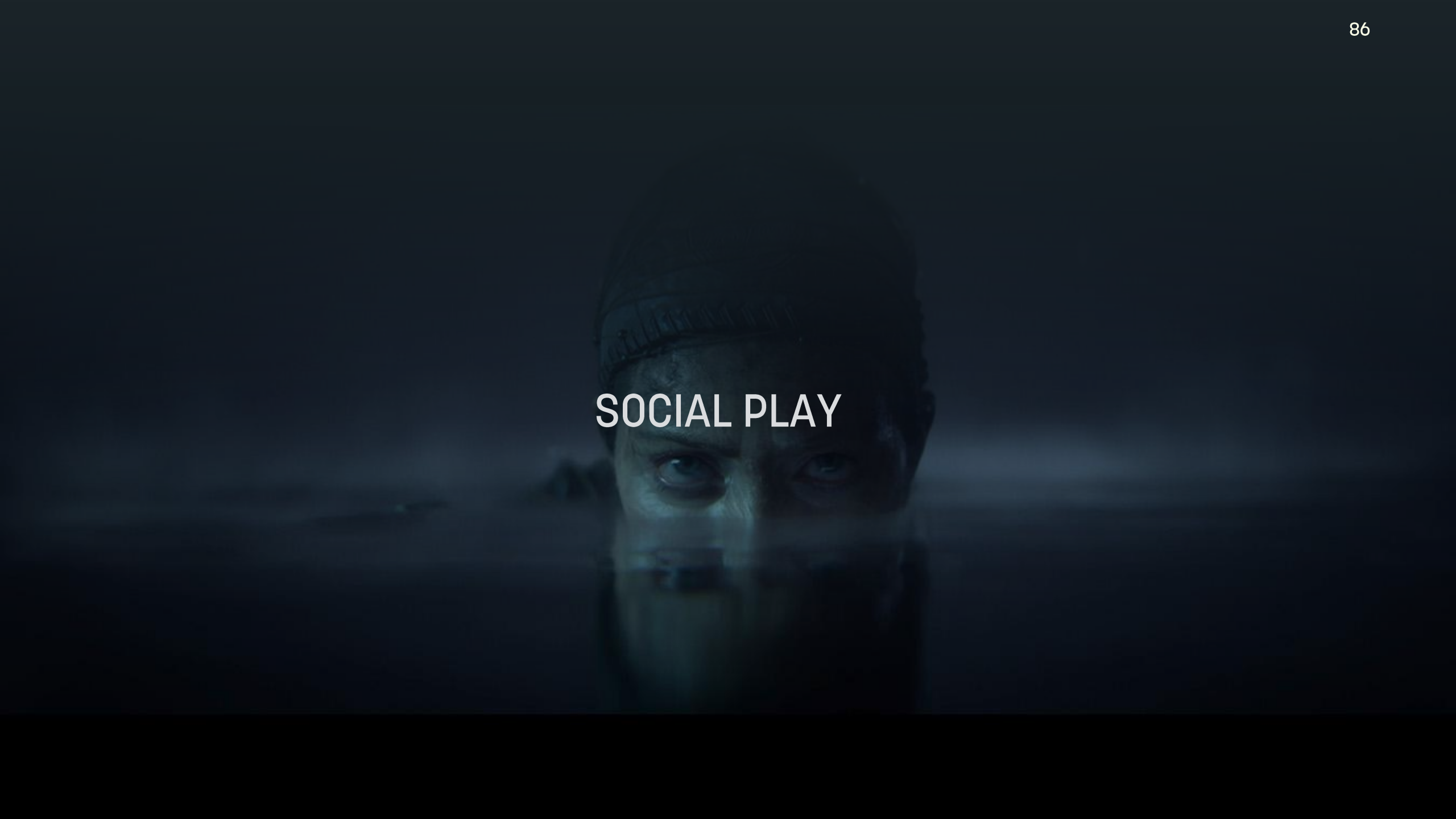
- Some players treat NPC relationships as serious
- Example: public 'marriage' to a Love Plus character
- Debate: escapism vs meaningful alternative
- Design questions about supportive vs avoidant play



THE SIMS: LIVING DOLLHOUSE

- Players create and customize Sims
- Manage needs: hunger, sleep, social, fun, environment
- Semi-autonomous behaviour blends control and observation



A dark, moody photograph of a person's face submerged in water. The person is looking directly at the camera with a serious expression. The water is dark and still, creating a clear reflection of the face below the surface. The lighting is low, highlighting the contours of the face and the texture of the water.

SOCIAL PLAY

WHY SOCIAL PLAY FEELS DIFFERENT

- Our choices affect others' outcomes
- Emotions shaped by shared success and failure
- Meaningful choices inside relationships



THREE BUILDING BLOCKS OF MULTIPLAYER EMOTION

- Coordinated action
 - Role-play through avatars
 - Social situations and norms
-
- Composable 'atoms' for emotional design



COORDINATED ACTION

- Shared hard tasks build rapport
- In games: co-op bosses, puzzles, rhythm games
- Success depends on genuine coordination



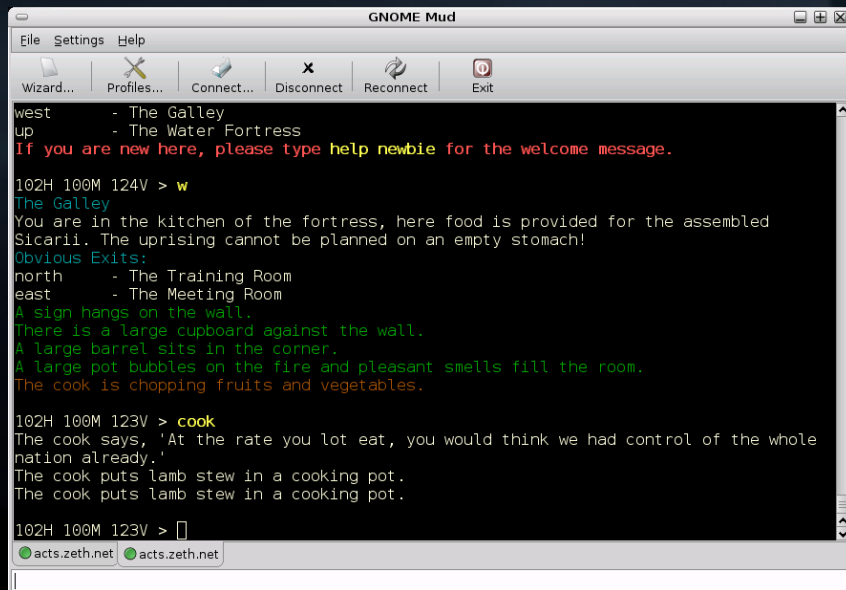
MULTIPLAYER AVATARS & ROLE-PLAY

- Avatars are performed in front of others
- Players take on roles: tank, healer, trickster, etc.
- Shared fictions: superheroes, pirates, crews
- Emotions: belonging, pride, performance anxiety



TEXT-BASED ROLE-PLAY: MUDS

- Multi-User Dungeons as text-only shared worlds
- Rich character descriptions and personas
- Collaborative world-building and role-play
- Text remains a powerful identity medium



The screenshot shows a window titled "GNOME Mud" with a menu bar (File, Settings, Help) and a toolbar with icons for Wizard, Profiles, Connect, Disconnect, Reconnect, and Exit. The main text area displays the following content:

```
west      - The Galley
up        - The Water Fortress
If you are new here, please type help newbie for the welcome message.

102H 100M 124V > w
The Galley
You are in the kitchen of the fortress, here food is provided for the assembled
Sicarii. The uprising cannot be planned on an empty stomach!
Obvious Exits:
north     - The Training Room
east      - The Meeting Room
A sign hangs on the wall.
There is a large cupboard against the wall.
A large barrel sits in the corner.
A large pot bubbles on the fire and pleasant smells fill the room.
The cook is chopping fruits and vegetables.

102H 100M 123V > cook
The cook says, 'At the rate you lot eat, you would think we had control of the whole
nation already.'
The cook puts lamb stew in a cooking pot.
The cook puts lamb stew in a cooking pot.

102H 100M 123V > 
```

At the bottom, there are two status bars, both showing "acts.zeth.net".



AVATARS SHAPING IDENTITY: ARTEMESIA

- Celia Pearce's avatar 'Artemesia' in virtual worlds
- Avatar becomes part of player's self-concept
- Others remember and talk about the avatar
- Avatars can become socially real



SOCIAL SITUATIONS & NORMS

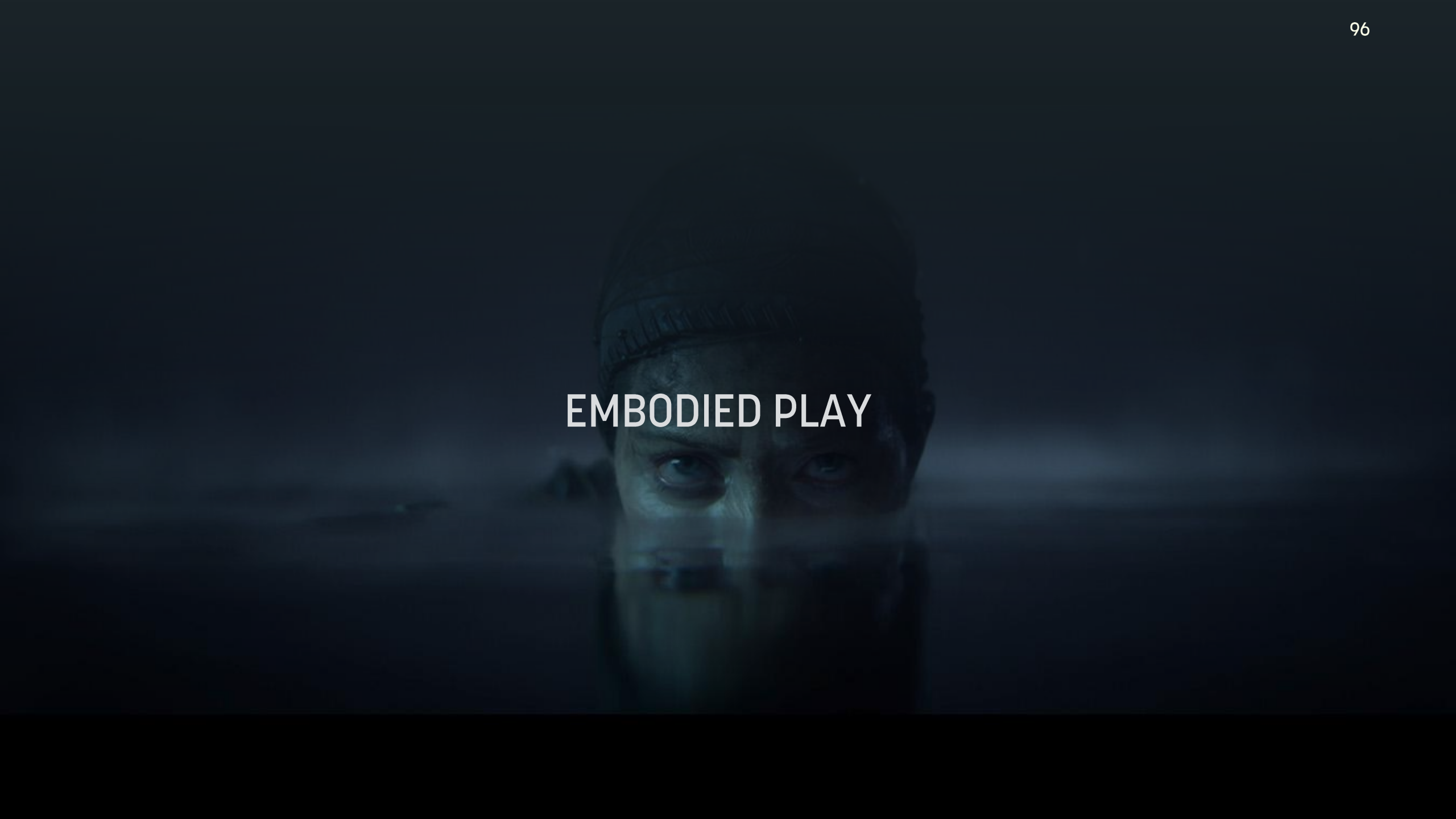
- Games create their own cultures and etiquette
- Norms around behaviour: 'gg', no griefing, etc.
- Roles, hierarchies, and conflicts emerge
- Design influences which norms take hold



MULTIPLAYER EMOTIONAL DESIGN: OPPORTUNITIES & PITFALLS

- Opportunities: friendship, teamwork, support
- Pitfalls: toxicity, bullying, addiction
- Design choices shape social climate



A dark, atmospheric photograph of a person's face, partially obscured by shadows and a headband, with the text "EMBODIED PLAY" overlaid in white capital letters. The person's eyes are visible, looking directly at the camera. The background is dark and blurry, suggesting an indoor setting with low lighting.

EMBODIED PLAY

FROM TWITCHING FINGERS TO FULL-BODY PLAY

- Traditional image: minimal movement at a desk
- Motion controllers, VR, AR, wearables change this
- Movement opens new emotional territory



MOTION & EMOTION: BODY FEEDBACK

- Body posture and expression influence feelings
- Smile muscles and 'power poses' affect mood and risk-taking
- Designers can leverage specific movements



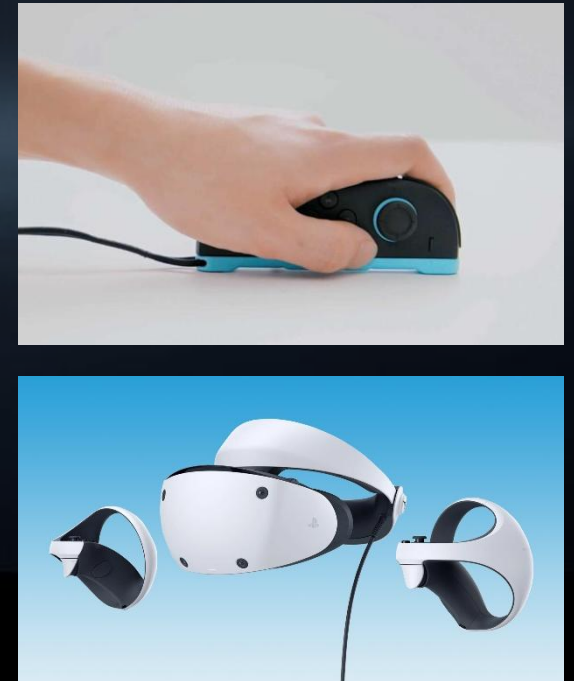
EMBODIED EMOTION IN PRETEND PLAY

- Children's pretend play involves full-body movement
- Example: foam sword fights vs static toys
- Movement increases arousal and immersion



RISE OF MOTION CONTROLLERS

- Nintendo Wii, Sony Move, Microsoft Kinect
- Tracking arm, hand, or whole-body movement
- Lower barrier to movement-based game design



PHYSICAL CHALLENGE AS EMOTIONAL TOOL

- Designers can tune fatigue and risk
- Balance games and VR heights evoke fear and relief
- Body becomes a design parameter for emotion



MOVEMENT AS SOCIAL GLUE

- Co-located movement games encourage eye contact and laughter
- Shared embarrassment can build bonds
- Synchronized movement creates feelings of unity



EMBODIMENT & AUGMENTATION: OPEN QUESTIONS

- Wearables and AR reshape body-technology relations
- Who is the 'real me' when my body is augmented?
- How do systems reshape presence and expectations?
- Games as labs for new body-tech relationships



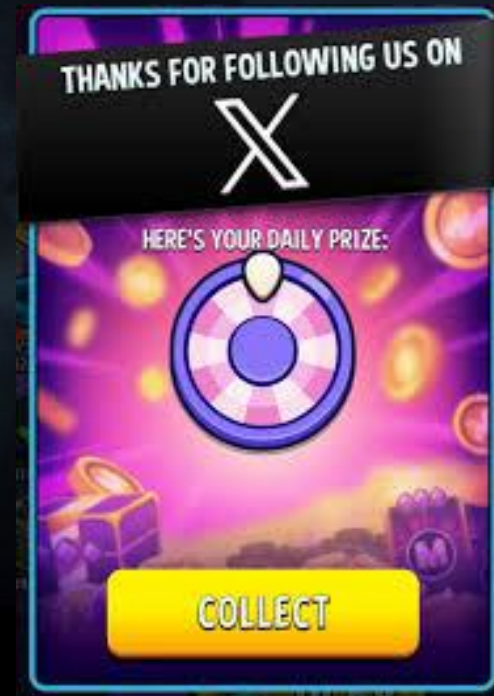
INVISIBLE INTIMACY

- Strong emotions often happen online at a distance
- From outside, it looks like 'just screen time'
- For players, it can mean deep friendships and grief



DIGITAL GIFTS & ASYNCHRONOUS TIES

- Everyday acts of care have game analogues
- Games allow sending items, buffs, or messages
- Example: Words With Friends as ongoing low-level connection



HOBBYIST & ACTIVIST COMMUNITIES

- Around games: fan art, mods, streams, charities
- Games as hubs for activism and mutual aid
- Players mobilize for causes beyond the game



RETHINKING 'SCREEN TIME'

- Common worries: isolation, distraction, 'addiction'
- Isbister: well-designed games can support connection and care
- When is play nurturing vs avoidance?



Disengagement From Games

Citation for published version (APA):

Alexandrovsky, D., Gerling, K., Opp, M. S., Hahn, C. B., Birk, M. V., & Alsheail, M. (2024). Disengagement From Games: Characterizing the Experience and Process of Exiting Play Sessions. *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction*, 8(CHI PLAY), Article 301. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3677066>

CHECKLIST: DESIGNING FOR EMOTION

- What core emotions do you want to evoke?
- How will choice, flow, avatars, NPCs, and movement support them?
- What social structures and network features are needed?
- Align all elements with desired emotional outcomes

THANK YOU FOR YOUR ATTENTION!

